Workstation Exercises

Recommendations to reduce aches and pains

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Why Stretch?

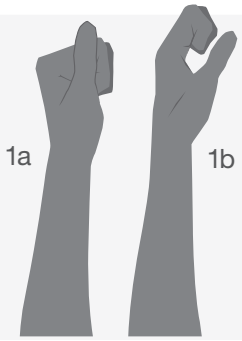
No matter how well the workstation is designed, problems may arise where work organisation is poor or disrupted. Working at a computer often involves few changes in body position. This lack of movement can lead to muscular aches and pains.

Recommendations to reduce aches and pains:

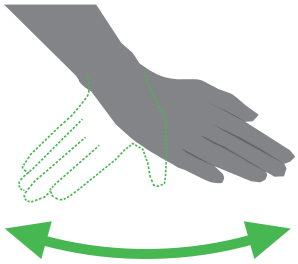
- Regularly vary work tasks, looking at organisation of the working day.
- Break up 'on-screen' activities with micro-breaks – tasks which involve movement, stretching and changes to body position.
- Try standing during some tasks and moving away from the workstation, for short periods, where possible.

Stretches for Wrist, Hand and Forearm

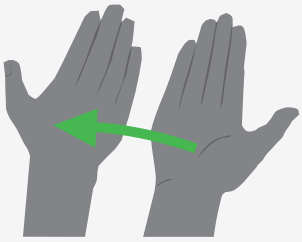
1. Make a fist; ensuring thumb is straight, not tucked under fingers (1a). Slide fingertips up palm, tips of fingers moving towards base of fingers, until stretch is felt (1b). Hold for slow count of 10. Repeat 3 – 5 times.



2. With hand open and facing down, move wrist from side to side, until stretch is felt at each extreme. Hold each for slow count of 10. Repeat 3 – 5 times.



3. With elbow held close in to side of body, slowly rotate palm upwards and then downwards until stretch is felt at each extreme. Hold each for slow count of 10. Repeat 3 – 5 times.



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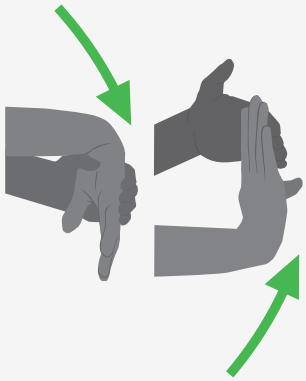
4.

Holding upper part of hand with other hand, slowly bend wrist down and then upwards until stretch is felt at each extreme. Hold each for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times.



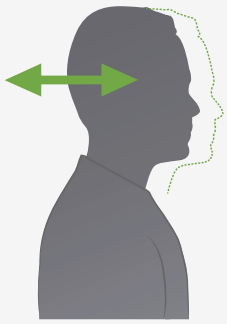
5.

Sitting with elbows out and palms together, slowly rotate palms down until stretch is felt. Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times.

Stretches for Neck and Shoulders

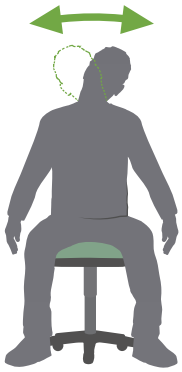
1.

Sit or stand upright. Without lifting chin, glide head straight back until a stretch is felt. Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times.



2.

Drop head slowly to one side, taking ear towards shoulder until stretch is felt. Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times to each side.



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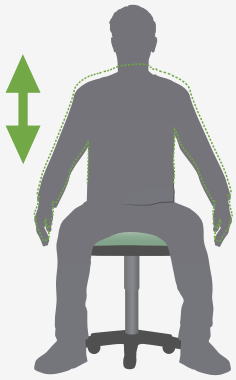
3.

Raise shoulders towards ears until slight tension felt across tops of shoulders. Hold for slow count of 10.
Release and repeat 3 – 5 times.



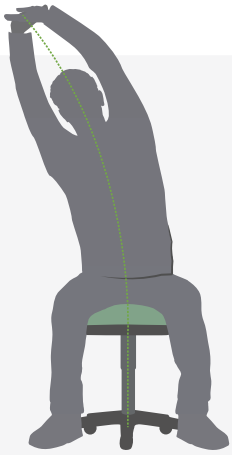
4.

Sitting with back supported, slowly roll shoulders up and backwards in circular motion.
Repeat 10 times.

Stretches for Back

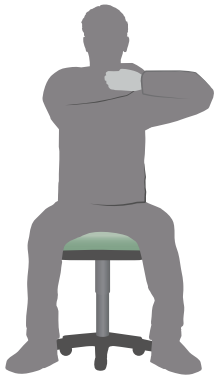
1.

Interlace fingers and lift arms above head, keeping elbows straight. Pressing arms back, slowly stretch to one side. Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times to each side.



2.

Hold right arm with left hand just above elbow. Gently push elbow towards left shoulder until stretch is felt. Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times to each side.



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3.

Interlace fingers and lift arms above head.
Slowly lean backwards until stretch is felt.
Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times.

Stretches for Leg and Ankle

1.

Slowly lift one leg, straightening knee.
Hold for slow count of 10.
Repeat 3 – 5 times with each leg.

2.

Lift ankle clear of floor.
Alternately flex and extend ankle in a pumping action.
Repeat 10 times with each ankle.

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